Understood?'

Yup. He actually said that. I couldn't believe it. It was just my second Test and I had seen the bitter reality of cricket politics already. That day I lost all my respect for Javed Miandad, supposedly one of the greats of the game but in reality, a small man.

I think I know what his problem is. Javed Miandad achieved great heights as a cricketer – bear in mind that my India obsession started with his six in Sharjah, one of the greatest moments the modern game has seen. But although he'd retired from the game, his sense of entitlement had not gone away. He wanted respect from anyone and everyone, at any cost. The situation is the same even today.

That's the thing about Javed Miandad. He lives in the past. His shadow is larger than himself. I feel it's the trait of a weak man. In his playing days, he earned himself a reputation, but retirement has brought out the worst in him. He even landed a political appointment – director general (DG) of the PCB. Nobody knows what he did as DG, though. In my opinion, no reforms, no new policies were implemented and nothing substantial was achieved during his tenure. Absolutely zilch, except six or seven years of a nice fat salary in his bank account.

The thing is, Javed bhai had – still has, maybe – a proximity complex. He would stick with those who performed. Those who were a bit inconsistent, like me, were dropped like a bad habit, perhaps because it was bad for his own reputation. Alas, he ruined one of my greatest cricket moments against my greatest rivals, by being, well, Javed Miandad. Being let down by your own, your elders, those you think you'd like to emulate, is the ultimate form of loss, especially in sport.

As for that series in India, we drew it 1–1. But cricket won. Big time. The crowds loved us. The press was all over us. It felt at the time that cricket in South Asia was back. However, for me, one of the gods of the game had fallen.

I have another sad tale, also from the field, about an episode surrounding another great innings. I was opening for Pakistan against India in the Sahara Cup at Toronto. Saeed Anwar, my fellow opener, didn't last long, and I was joined in the middle by the captain, Aamer Sohail.

I started with a six on the first ball and followed it up with two or three fours. The crowd went crazy. As the Indian bowler went to his captain to get some advice, Aamer came up to me. I approached him halfway on the track, for it looked like he wanted to discuss something. As soon as Aamer was near enough, he cussed at me, calling me a terrible name, and said: 'I know you've fixed this match with Wasim Akram. I know what you're up to, Afridi.'

My heart sank. This was in '97 or '98. I was young and just getting started in the game. I burst into tears in the middle of that pitch, with the game underway. But I recovered quickly – I went back to the crease, composed myself and tried to focus. Eventually, I succeeded; I scored a century.

Later, when I returned to the dressing room, Aamer, who had got out earlier than me, came up to the players' gallery and said, 'Stay on my side. Join me. I will connect you with the right people. I can help you run Pakistan cricket.' I just glared at him and walked away.

Later, I told Wasim bhai and Inzi bhai about the incident. They told me to keep the episode to myself and handle the situation gracefully and silently. Aamer Sohail was the captain, after all. I'm not sure where his insecurity came from, although I have a rough idea: it's about fame, or the lack of it, particularly in his case.

Remember, I was just a young lad, compared to these legends, these gods of cricket I was